

LEARNING AND BUILDING WITH AI, IN PUBLIC

The First Build

How I built a morning brief that writes itself, what every decision cost me, and how to make your own.

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START HERE

What this is

Three mornings a week, before I start work, an email is waiting for me. It has the news that matters to me, in the order I care about, in language I can use. Nobody writes it. I set it up once and it has run ever since.

This document is the whole thing. Not a summary, not a demo. The actual instructions I use, the decisions behind each one, the parts I got wrong, and enough detail that you can build your own version by the end of an evening.

I am not a developer. I studied business law, I have no computer science degree, and I built this around a full time job. I mention that early because the biggest barrier here is not difficulty, it is the assumption that this sort of thing is for other people. It is not. There is no code in this guide.

ONE THING TO KNOW BEFORE YOU START

This guide is free, and so is everything on my website. Nothing here will ever ask you for money.

What I should flag on page one rather than page nine: the setup runs on **Claude Code**, which is Anthropic's tool, and using it properly means one of their paid plans. There is a free tier you can experiment with, but a task that runs on a schedule and searches the web will need a subscription. That is their pricing rather than mine, so check their site for what it costs today.

For what it is worth, I recommend it without hesitation. It is the most useful subscription I pay for. Everything I have built in the last year, including the project in this guide, came out of it, and if you want to actually try things rather than read about them, it earns its keep quickly.

THE RESULT

What you will end up with

Mine is called **Northbound Notes**. It arrives three mornings a week before I start work, and it covers the weather where I am, the world news that actually matters to me, what moved in financial services and in AI, the market numbers I follow, and one thing worth saying out loud that day. It takes under three minutes to read and it is written for exactly one person.

Here is the shape of it. The content below is an illustration rather than a real issue, but the structure and voice are exactly what the instructions produce.

Toronto today

22°C and clear, light wind. **Nothing you need to plan around.**

The big picture

Two central banks moved in opposite directions this week, and **the gap between them is now the widest since 2019.**

Why it matters: currency pairs move on divergence like this, and it tends to show up in import costs within a quarter.

AI

A new open weights model claims performance close to the leading closed models at a fraction of the cost. **The benchmark it leads on is not the one most people care about.**

Why it matters: the number worth tracking is cost per useful task, and nobody publishes that.

Numbers that moved

Nvidia +3.1% on supply commentary, not earnings. Nasdaq +0.8%. Oil -2.4% on demand revisions.

Conversation starter

Most companies now report an AI pilot. Very few report a decommissioned process. **The gap between those two numbers is the real adoption rate.** Worth asking anyone who says their organisation is doing AI: what did you stop doing?

Every item leads with the point, and every item says why it matters. That is the entire design, and most of this guide is about why it ended up that way rather than how to type it in.

NONE OF THIS STRUCTURE IS FIXED

These are my sections because this is my brief. Yours should look different. Drop the markets if you do not follow them, add one on your industry, your city council, your sport, your reading. The only section I would argue hard for keeping is the last one, and I will explain why later.

Treat what follows as a worked example to take apart, not a template to obey.

BACKGROUND

Why I built it

I was starting every morning the same way. Five or six sources, twenty minutes of scrolling, and I would still walk into a meeting with nothing useful to say. Not because I was uninformed, but because I had read a lot of things that were not connected to anything I actually did.

The problem was never a shortage of news. It was that everything available was written for everybody. A general business newsletter cannot know that I care about AI regulation and not about retail earnings, that I am in Toronto, or that I would like one good opening line before a call.

So I stopped looking for a better newsletter and wrote instructions for one instead.

THE IDEA WORTH TAKING

The interesting part is not the brief. It is that a set of plain English instructions, written once, can do a job for you indefinitely. A morning brief is just the easiest place to see that clearly. Once you have built one, you start noticing the other jobs that look the same.

CONCEPTS

The three ideas you need

Most guides skip this and lose people at step one. These are the only three things you need to understand, and none of them are technical.

1. An instruction file

A plain text file where you write, in ordinary English, what you want done. No syntax, no commands, no punctuation rules. If you can write a clear brief for a new colleague, you can write one of these. The whole system in this guide is one such file, and you will see all of it later.

2. A scheduled task

Claude Code can run an instruction file on a timer, without you being there to ask. That is all "scheduled task" means. You say *every Monday, Wednesday and Friday at eight*, and it happens.

3. A connector

A connector is permission for the tool to use one of your accounts. In this case, your email, so it can leave the finished brief where you will see it. You grant it explicitly, you can see what it is allowed to do, and you can revoke it.

PUT TOGETHER

You write instructions once. A timer runs them. A connector delivers the result. That is the entire architecture, and it is worth holding onto because almost every useful automation you build later is the same three pieces in a different order.

STEP ONE

Getting set up

You need Claude Code installed and an email account connected. If you have never opened a terminal, I have a free course that walks through installation from absolute zero at mubienahsan.com/courses. It assumes nothing.

Connecting your email

The connector is the part people are rightly cautious about, so here is what actually happens. You authorise the tool against your mail account through your provider's own permission screen, the same one you see when any app asks for access. You see the list of permissions before you agree. You can withdraw it later from your account settings.

Two things worth deciding before you click:

- **Use a personal account, not a work one.** Your employer almost certainly has a policy about connecting third party tools to corporate mail, and this is not the thing to find that out on.
- **Understand the difference between drafting and sending.** I deliberately set mine to create a draft rather than send. More on that later, because it turned out to be the most important decision in the build.

BE DELIBERATE ABOUT THIS ONE

Granting a tool access to your inbox is a real decision, not a formality. Read the permissions screen. If you are not comfortable, you can still build everything in this guide and have the brief written to a file on your own machine instead. The email step is convenience, not necessity.

STEP TWO

The instruction file, line by line

This is mine, with my employer's name taken out and nothing else changed. Read it once, then I will go through why each part is there. The annotations are the useful bit.

```
---
name: morning-brief
description: Mon/Wed/Fri 8AM email brief
---
```

Create a concise morning news brief and deliver it as an email draft.

Who this is for

Mubien Ahsan, based in Toronto. I want short, punchy talking points I could raise in a thirty second conversation with a colleague or a client and sound sharp. I also build AI side projects in the evenings, so practical AI and product news is extra relevant.

Steps

1. Use web search to gather TODAY'S latest on each section below. Prioritise the last 48 hours. Use reputable sources.
2. Get today's weather forecast for Toronto.
3. Compose the email in the structure below.
4. Create a draft addressed to me, subject: "Northbound Notes – {Day}, {Month Date}".

Sections, in this order

1. **Toronto today** – one line: conditions, high and low in Celsius, and anything actionable such as an umbrella or a heat warning.
2. **The big picture** – 2 to 3 major world events. One short paragraph each: what happened, and why it matters.
3. **Financial services** – 2 to 3 items on banks, insurance, fintech, regulation, payments.
4. **AI moves** – 2 to 3 items: model releases, enterprise adoption, regulation, notable funding.
5. **Market movers** – biggest moves: ticker, % move, one line reason.
6. **Conversation starter** – one opener for the day: a surprising stat, a bold prediction, or a question worth posing, with a two sentence setup.

Style rules

- Each item is a thirty second sound bite: 2 to 4 sentences max, plain language, no jargon without a quick explanation.
- Lead every item with the hook, not the background.
- Include a "why it matters" angle in each item.
- Bold the single most important phrase in each item.
- Skip any section with nothing worth saying. Never pad.
- If you cannot confirm a number from a named source, say so or leave it out.
- Total email readable in under five minutes.

Done when

A draft exists with today's date in the subject, containing only the sections that had something worth saying.

That is the whole system. Roughly forty lines of English. Now the reasons.

ANNOTATIONS

Why each part is there

WHO THIS IS FOR

This section does more work than everything else combined. "I work in finance" gets you a generic brief. Naming your city, your field, who you talk to and what you do in the evenings gives it enough to judge what is relevant. Every time my brief has been boring, the fix has been here, not in the sections.

PRIORITISE THE LAST 48 HOURS

Without a recency rule you get well written summaries of things you read last week. The window matters more than the sources.

CREATE A DRAFT, NOT A SENT EMAIL

The most important line in the file. A draft waits for me. It means nothing is ever sent on my behalf, I read everything before it counts, and if an issue is wrong it is wrong privately. Automating all the way to send would save me one click and cost me the only checkpoint in the system.

LEAD WITH THE HOOK, NOT THE BACKGROUND

Default output builds up to the point. That is fine for an essay and useless at seven in the morning. This one instruction did more for readability than any other.

INCLUDE A "WHY IT MATTERS" ANGLE

This is a quality filter disguised as a formatting rule. If a genuine reason cannot be written, the item was not worth including, and the instruction quietly removes weak items without me having to define what weak means.

BOLD THE MOST IMPORTANT PHRASE

Borrowed from Axios. It lets you read the whole brief in twenty seconds and stop wherever you want. Small change, large effect.

SKIP ANY SECTION WITH NOTHING WORTH SAYING

My original said the opposite. If a section was quiet I told it to find something adjacent to fill the space, and it obliged, every time, with filler. A short brief is a good brief. This is the rule I would give you if you could only take one.

IF YOU CANNOT CONFIRM A NUMBER, SAY SO

It is assembling this from the open web at speed, and it is occasionally confidently wrong. This does not eliminate that. It does mean uncertainty is usually labelled rather than smoothed over, which is the difference between a useful colleague and a liability.

STEP THREE

Run it, then schedule it

Save your version of the file, then **run it once by hand before scheduling anything**. This is the step people skip and it is the one that matters.

Read what comes back and argue with it. It will be about seventy percent right. Note what irritated you, change the instructions, run it again. Mine took four passes before it stopped telling me things I already knew.

Only once you have an issue you would genuinely want to read should you put it on a timer. Ask Claude Code to schedule it for the days and time you want.

WHAT "TUNING" ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

It is not clever prompting. It is reading the output and asking one question: *what annoyed me?* Then writing a sentence that prevents it. Every rule in my file started as an annoyance. That loop is the whole skill, and it is the same loop whether you are building a brief or an application.

DECISIONS

What I got wrong

The parts nobody puts in a tutorial, and the reason this guide is worth more than a demo.

Seven sections was too many

I started with seven, adding an industry section on top of the six you have just read. It was thorough and I stopped reading it properly within two weeks. There is a length past which a brief stops being a shortcut and becomes another task.

I am at six now and I would still cut one more. Whatever number you start with, the honest test is whether you read it all the way to the bottom on a busy morning. If you do not, it is too long, and the fix is removing a section rather than shortening every item.

Daily was worse than three times a week

Daily meant thin issues and a mounting sense of obligation. Monday, Wednesday and Friday gives each one enough to say and leaves gaps where things can actually happen. Less often was more valuable, which I did not expect.

I told it to pad, without realising

"If quiet, cover something adjacent" sounds sensible and it is a licence to waffle. I read filler for weeks before I worked out I had asked for it. If your output feels padded, look for the instruction that permits it.

My first version was too polite about uncertainty

Early issues stated soft numbers with the same confidence as hard ones. Nothing catastrophic, but I nearly repeated a figure in a meeting that I could not have sourced. The confirmation rule came out of that, and it is why I still click through before quoting anything.

I over specified the tone and it went flat

An early version had six rules about voice. The result read like a corporate memo. I cut it back to "plain language, no jargon without explanation" and it improved immediately. Constrain the structure, leave the voice alone.

YOURS

Making it your own

The structure transfers. The content should not. Two worked examples:

A TEACHER

Who this is for: a secondary school teacher in Manchester, teaching sciences, interested in education policy and classroom technology.

Sections: education policy and funding · one teaching idea worth stealing · technology in classrooms · something to open a lesson with.

SOMEONE STARTING A BUSINESS

Who this is for: starting a small food business, no investors, learning as they go.

Sections: what changed for small businesses this week · a competitor or a good idea worth noticing · one practical thing to do today · a question to sit with.

Notice that neither is about markets. The template is not a finance product. It is a way of getting somebody to read the world on your behalf and report back in your language.

The one section I would keep whatever you build

Both examples end with something to say rather than something to know, and that is deliberate. Every other section reports what happened. The conversation starter gives you a line, a question, or a number you can actually use in front of another person that day.

It is the only part of my brief that changes how a morning goes rather than just what I know by the end of it. If you strip yours back to two sections, make this one of them.

Three rules that transfer whatever you build

- **Explain who you are properly.** Specificity is the whole game.
- **Let it skip things.** Permission to say nothing is what keeps quality up.
- **Keep a checkpoint.** Draft rather than send. Review rather than trust.

CARE

What to watch for

It will be confidently wrong sometimes

This is assembled from the open web at speed. Most of it is accurate. Occasionally a number is wrong or a claim is stale, and it will be stated in exactly the same tone as everything else. Confidence is not a signal. Before you repeat a figure to anyone whose opinion of you matters, click the source.

Be careful what you put in the instructions

The file describes your job, your interests and your city. That is fine. Do not put anything confidential in it, anything about your employer's internal work, or anything about clients. Keep it to what you would happily say at a conference.

Watch the drift

After a couple of months your interests move and the brief does not. Reread the file every so often. Mine has been rewritten four times and will be again.

THE HABIT UNDERNEATH ALL OF THIS

Nothing is finished because a tool said it is finished. The draft step, the confirmation rule and the review loop are all the same instinct: a human looks before it counts. That is the most useful thing I brought from my day job, and it matters more the better these tools get.

LAST THING

Go and build something

If you take one idea from this, let it be that the brief is not the point. The point is that you can describe a job in plain English, hand it over, keep a checkpoint for yourself, and have it done from then on. Once that lands, you start seeing candidates everywhere.

Your first build does not have to be impressive. Mine sends me an email. It has to be finished, because finished is the part that teaches you.

If you build one, I would genuinely like to hear about it. Tell me what it does and what went wrong, since the second part is always more interesting. My address is on the site.

Everything at mubienahsan.com is free: courses that start from absolute zero, the projects I have built with what each one taught me, and honest notes on what is worth learning.

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